

Burial Diversity in Chalcolithic Anatolia: an Analysis

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Overview

Located centrally in modern day Turkey, the Anatolian Plateau was the site of widely diverse burial practices during the Chalcolithic period (ca. 6000–3000 BCE). The largest category of burials in this region were subadult pithoi burials (jar burials) interred intramurally with 92 burials. However, this category only made up 34% of the total burials for the region indicating an impressive diversity in burial practices for this time [1]. With such diversity though, some questions arise. What was the cause of having so many burial traditions and where and how were the adults interred?

Methods

This visualization represents a comprehensive review of the current mortuary materials published on the Chalcolithic Anatolian Plateau to date. Data was collected from the excavation reports on 18 sites geographically separated into four subregions. All burial data was analyzed for location (intra- versus extramural placement), age, and burial type as well as demographic information such as sex, though little data on this exists and thus is not represented here.

When considering categorization of burials, individuals 0-3 years were identified as infants, 3-12 years as children, 12-20 years as adolescents, and 20+ years as adults, in keeping with the standards set forth by Buikstra and Ubelaker (1994) [2]. Only 8 possible burials of adolescents were identified in the dataset and as such they have been included in the adult dataset. Thus our categories are defined as subadults aged 0-12 and adults aged 12+.

Correlations Between Burial Variables

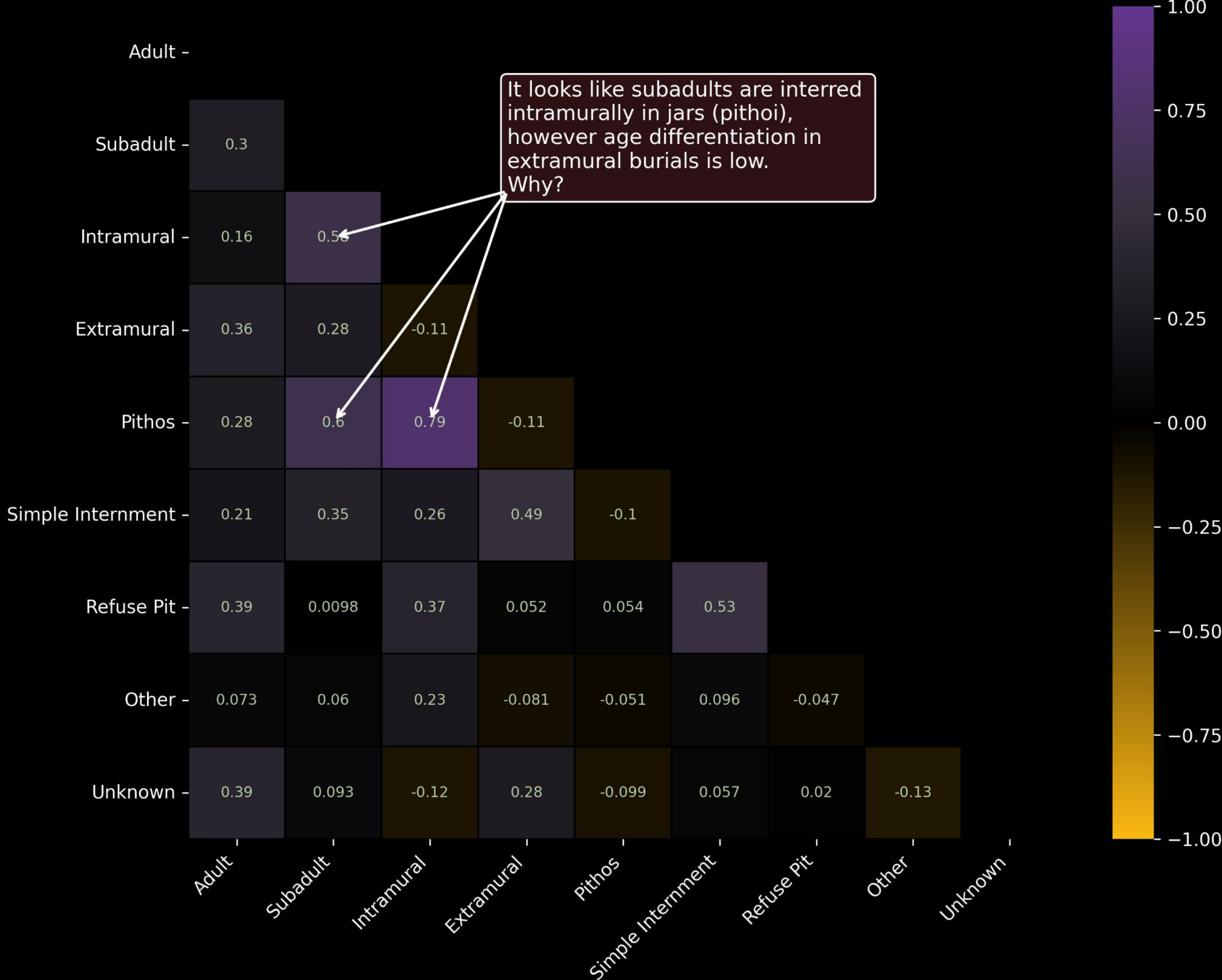


Figure 1 - a heatmap showing correlation between different burial variables in the dataset.

In Fig. 1 the highest correlation we see is between Pithos and Intramural implying a traditional and/or practical aspect to the spatial practice. There is notably a low adult-extramural correlation which challenges any inference that adults were systematically buried extramurally. This low extramural-adult correlation may result from few such adult extramural burials being located as no Chalcolithic adult cemeteries have been found to date in Central Anatolia possibility indicating that adults were primarily interred alone [1].

Adult and Subadult Burials by Subregion

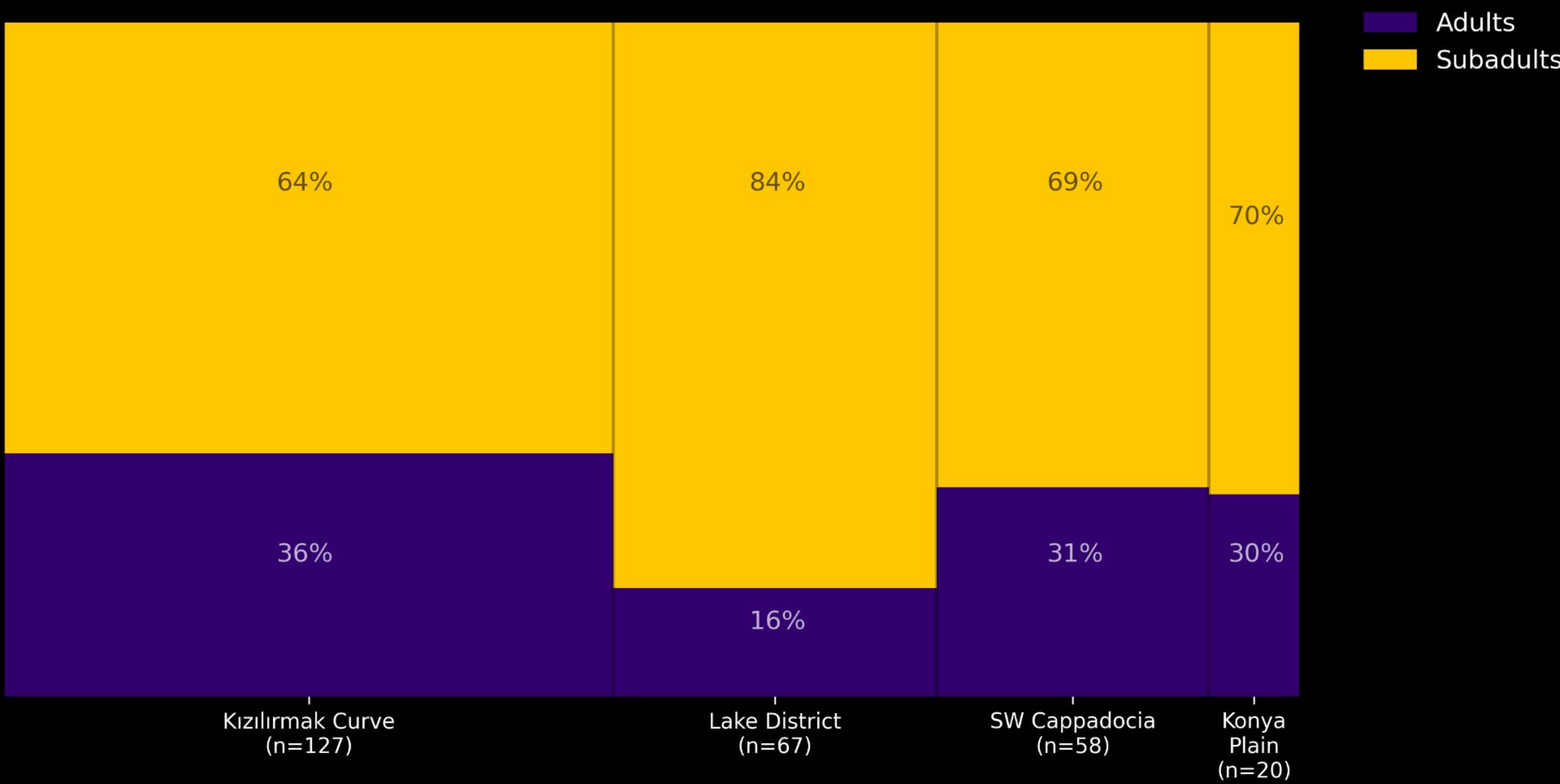
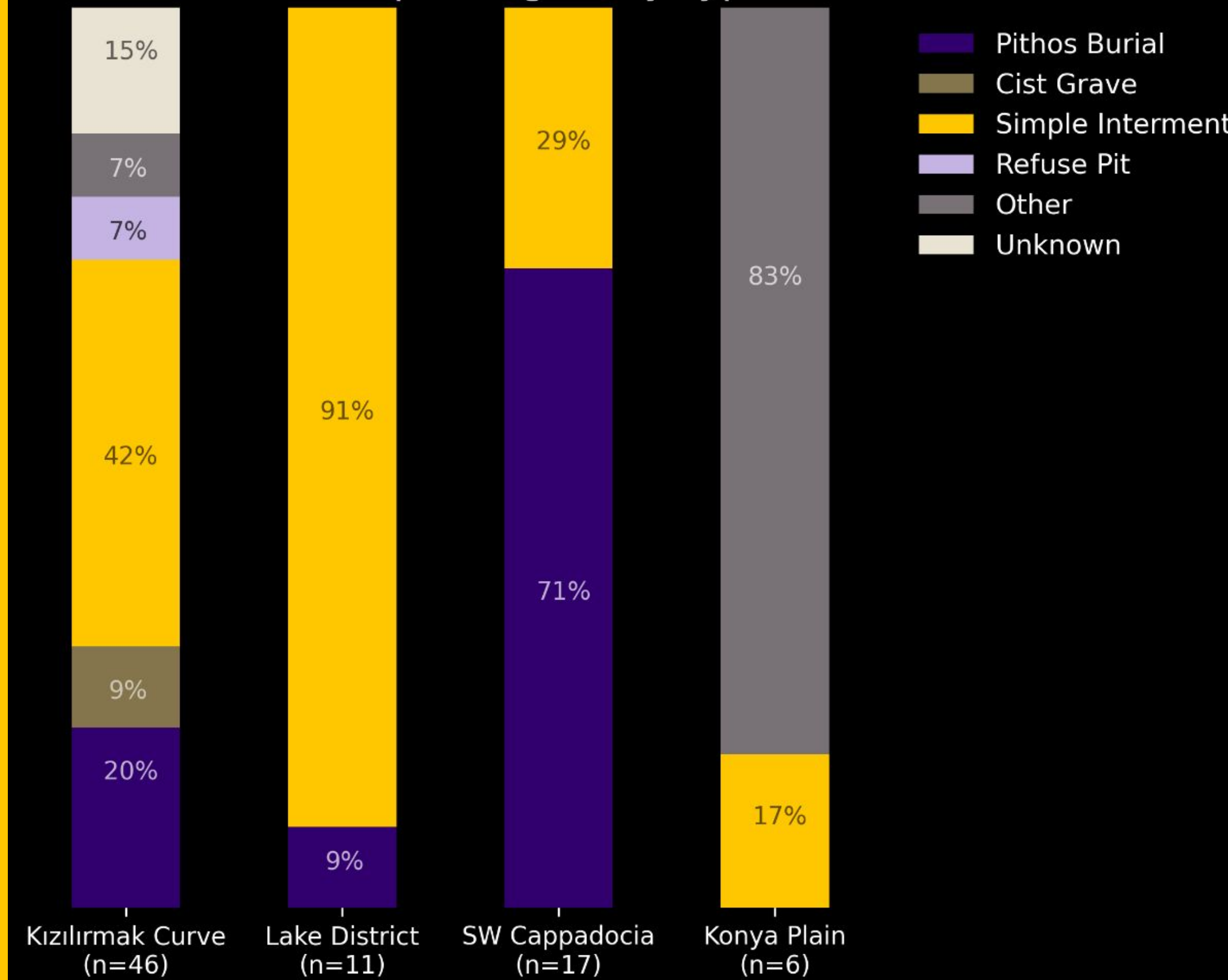


Figure 2 - a plot showing sample size per subregion as width and percentage of subadult versus adult burials as height.

We see a remarkably consistent 30-36% adult burials in all but the Lake District, why? The Lake District subregional dataset is dominated by the site of Kuruçay Höyük which has the highest percentage of subadult burials of any site in the dataset. Though there are only two other sites in the Lake District, with only 9 total burials with known ages between them, we see that removing Kuruçay from the dataset results in 33% adult and 67% subadult burials for the rest of the subregion bringing it in line with the the other three subregions. This indicates that potentially the site of Kuruçay Höyük practiced different mortuary rituals from the surrounding sites.

Adult Burials per Region by Type



Subdult Burials per Region by Type

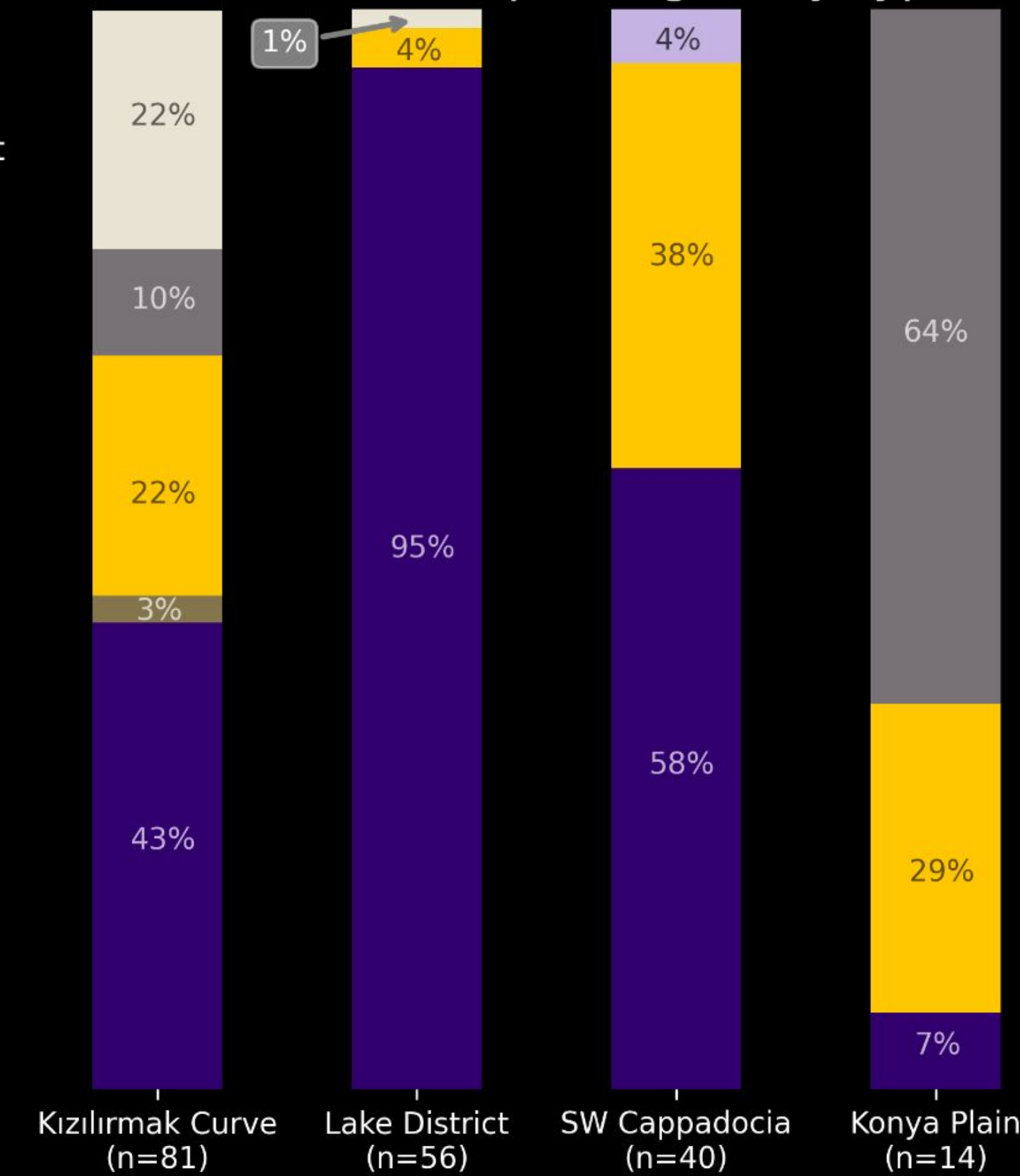


Figure 3 - a comparison of percentage of burial types for each subregion broken out by age.

While in general there appears to be a preference for adults to be buried in simple interments and subadults in pithoi burials, we see a high amount of burial diversity in Chalcolithic Central Anatolia in both age groups particularly in the Kızılırmak Curve. While the Kızılırmak Curve as a whole makes up 47% of the dataset, this does not appear to be the cause of the observed diversity as the other subadult subregions do not show such diversity despite having comparable sample size to the adult Kızılırmak Curve dataset which does show diverse practices. This potentially indicates different mortuary rituals practiced in the Kızılırmak Curve compared to the other three subregions.

Conclusion

The peoples of the Chalcolithic Anatolian Plateau primarily interred subadults intramurally in pithoi burials, however this practice was far from standardized as we see a wide diversity of burial types particularly in the Kızılırmak Curve. While simple interment was the most common way that adults were interred, there is such a high diversity of adult burials as to result in a low overall correlation. Additionally, while there was a preference to bury subadults intramurally, there appears to be no such correlation with extramural adult burial. Finally, the site of Kuruçay Höyük and the subregion of the Kızılırmak Curve were identified as potentially hosting regionally unique mortuary rituals.

[1] Yıldırım, B., Selover, S., Amiotte-Beaulieu, M. (2026). *Holding Close, Letting Go: Burials and Belonging on the Chalcolithic Anatolian Plateau*. [Unpublished manuscript]. Routledge.

[2] Buikstra, J.E. and Ubelaker, D.H., eds. (1994) Standards for Data Collection from Human Skeletal Remains: Proceedings of a Seminar at the Field Museum of Natural History. Fayetteville, AK: Arkansas Archaeological Survey.